

Iris Long, Yanlin Lu

ARCHIVE

GRANT ALLOCATED \$12,500778

One-Sentence Description

A cultural reconstruction of the Chinese engagement with anomalous bodily phenomena from 1979-1999.

Proposed Project

Iris and Yanlin are resurfacing the historical episode of anomalous bodily phenomena research in China from 1979 to 1999. This historical research program examined a wide range of phenomena illegible to modern biomedicine, including extrasensory perception and efficacy of traditional Chinese medicine.

Iris and Yanlin will undertake a systematic re-examination of archive materials (scientific publications, conference proceedings, internal reports, media) and conduct oral interviews with key researchers, practitioners and observers who participated or witnessed these experiments. They will then identify how experimental questions from this historical program resonate with current research areas, particularly embodied cognition, biofeedback, neuroscience and human perception studies.

The long-term goal output for this project at large will be a book. For Revival, Iris is inviting 5 artists to reenact the experiments with artistic inputs. Iris and Yanlin are interested in reactivating this forgotten field of inquiry by circulating their research outcome in multiple channels in both China and the US/UK and in multi-media forms: writing, public discussion and visual materials. They will engage with both academic communities and broader cultural audiences, reopening a space for generative discussion between science, philosophy and imagination.

Revival Relevance

“Somatic science (Renti kexue)” was coined by Qian Xuesen—the father of Chinese rocketry—in 1981, who framed the human body as a cybernetic, “open complex giant system” with multiple “functional states.” He believed that human consciousness could bring the body into an altered functional state with “extraordinary functions”, including psychic abilities. Research programs on somatic science, both from top-down and bottom-up levels, became hugely popular in China throughout the 80s. ¹

While considered by critics as “the greatest pseudoscience movement in contemporary China”, this was a serious national effort under the umbrella ambition of an “Eastern Scientific Revolution.” Research programs and outcomes from this historical episode raise important questions around what constitutes science and the limits to delineating epistemic objects.

The conceptual vocabulary of “functional states”, in addition, are reminiscent of today’s emerging fields in embodied cognition, bioelectric morphogenesis and systems-based psychosomatic medicine. This Revival project could present a curious case of a lost system of research (including its vocabulary and methodology)

¹ CIA document from 2000: [cia.gov/readingroom/docs/CIA-RDP96-00792R000300290004-0.pdf](https://www.cia.gov/readingroom/docs/CIA-RDP96-00792R000300290004-0.pdf)

with renewed perspectives for today's work identifying how the body senses, integrates and processes information in complex models.

Wendi's Notes

1. Iris & Yanlin's track record of rigorous research

Yanlin is a PhD candidate at Princeton specializing in this topic of research, advised by Michael Gordin (History of Science professor specializing in Cold War history, pseudoscience research history, among other topics). Yanlin has already collected extensive written and oral materials for the research, and was recently invited by Journal of Anomalistics to write an article on his research.

Iris is a preeminent writer and curator in art, science and technology in the Chinese context. During her fellowship at the Berggruen Institute China Center, she organized the art and technology exhibition [The Larva of Time](#), locating the question of time in its technological, biological, geological and humanistic folds. She also organized the multi-year research project Under the Cloud, which brought together sci-fi writers, artists, technologists to visit data centers, radio astronomy centers, meteorological bureaus, and the FAST telescope in Guizhou. This expansive project culminated in several lectures and [an extensive publication](#) with research images, sci-fi stories, ethnographic notes and artistic contributions.

The Works in Progress magazine recently got in touch with Iris, showing interest in expanding the publication into China. Iris is interested in writing an article on this project for the magazine.

2. "Nontraditional" output is well suited for the research topic

At the Revival Fund, we are interested in supporting nontraditional research outcomes: in the interest of true revival, we should allow the ideas under investigation to inform the form of how it should be communicated. Iris and Yanlin's project is a particularly good example of the idea demanding to be shared in open-ended formats.

Given Iris's extensive experience in creative research publishing (often combining technical writing, ethnographic images, speculative fiction, and artistic experimentation), I am confident that the resulting publication and activities will be holistically, rigorously pursued. Iris and Yanlin are deeply aligned with our editorial values, and we will work together throughout the year to scope out the sensible form for communicating the research.

3. "Wild-card" research implications

I am particularly excited about funding this project due to the vast possibilities it has in research impact.

For example, the archival materials on *qigong* functional states and "extraordinary perception" could be productively re-read as early attempts to map the same interoceptive predictive landscape in neuroscience today, offering insights into or provocative questions on interoceptive plasticity.